‘conference’ and announced that the Chinese had ambushed his column and that there was a roadblock at KM 31.

Pathania then gave his last two formal orders as GOC 4 Division. He de-linked 4 Rajput from 65 Infantry Brigade and put it under the command of 62 Infantry Brigade with the job of covering the brigade’s withdrawal from Se-la. He then ordered the two companies of 13 Dogra that had arrived at Dirang Dzong from Senge during the night to clear the roadblock, with support from the Stuart tanks of B Squadron of 7 Cavalry.

There were close to 5,000 soldiers present at Dirang Dzong. Apart from Major General Pathania, there were three brigade commanders, two of whom were fast asleep at the time of the conference. The end of the conference was more like the end of a school day when children come tumbling out of their classrooms. 13 Dogra, having just arrived, was told to move for the assault within minutes. With no idea of the geography, it didn’t know where to go. By then it was every man for himself and the roads were already getting clogged while senior officers got their personal belongings loaded onto their vehicles.

The bewildered Dogras barely made it to Sagor. Three tanks under Major S. D. S. Jamwal set out with the Dogra troops, but could not proceed any further as the roads were blocked with fleeing troops. The cavalrymen soon abandoned their tanks that were then pushed off the road into the valley below to clear the road. The GOC and his entourage followed in their loaded vehicles to officially ‘watch the battle’, but at Sagor their small convoy got stuck. 86 Field Battery, located below Sagor, had visual contact with Munna Camp that was by then occupied by Chinese troops. The guns defiantly opened up with their 25-pounders causing substantial casualties among the Chinese. Taken by surprise, the Chinese in turn fired a few rounds of mortars that were sporadic and quite ineffective. Though the Chinese troops were unlikely to have enough ammunition—having come cross country across the passes—the Chinese counter-bombardment convinced the GOC and his entourage to abandon their vehicles and take to their feet, heading for the Manda-la track that bifurcates to the west and then south from Sagor.

Those present in Dirang Dzong during that fateful period say Cheema and Manohar Singh, the GSO-1, were the ones whispering in Pathania’s ear, spinning a web of negativity, constantly urging him to make a dash for the plains of Assam before the Chinese surrounded them completely. During